LinkedIn Job Search Optimization

Product Experimentation Case Study

Product Strategy | Experiment Design | Product Metrics | Trust & Safety

Overview

Product: LinkedIn Jobs

Target User: Students and recent graduates actively searching for internships and new-grad opportunities

Problem:

From my experience searching for internships and jobs on LinkedIn, some opportunities appear on LinkedIn after I have already seen them on publicly curated GitHub repositories or Simplify. For students and recent graduates applying to competitive roles, delayed discovery can mean applying later in the recruiting process or missing an opportunity entirely.

Why It Matters:

For time-sensitive internship and new-grad recruiting, the value of a job-search platform depends not only on the number of opportunities it shows, but also on how quickly users discover them. If candidates consistently find newly posted opportunities earlier through other sources, they may rely less on LinkedIn as their primary job-discovery platform.

Current Experience

- I currently rely on community-curated sources such as GitHub repositories and job-alert tools to discover newly posted internships and new-grad opportunities.
- After finding a new posting, I often use LinkedIn to identify and connect with employees at the company rather than relying on LinkedIn as the initial discovery source.
- I notice the timing gap when a LinkedIn posting already shows substantial applicant activity by the time I encounter it, even though I previously saw the same opportunity through another source.
- This can result in students entering an already-active recruiting process, where interviews may already be scheduled or candidate pipelines may already be filling.

Main Friction:

LinkedIn becomes less useful to me as a primary internship-discovery tool when strong-fit roles at competitive companies surface only after the recruiting cycle is already underway. When I relied primarily on LinkedIn Jobs, I found that I sometimes discovered roles matching my skills and interests later than I did through more actively curated job sources.

Solutions Considered

- **Option 1: Community-submitted early-career job discovery**
  Allow verified university students or recent graduates to contribute links to newly opened internship and new-grad roles. LinkedIn could verify contributors through university or work email addresses and validate submitted job links against official employer domains, while keeping employer-owned job pages under company control.
- **Option 2: Partner with specialized job-discovery platforms**
  LinkedIn could partner with specialized job-discovery platforms such as Simplify or Jobright.ai that focus on aggregating and surfacing newly opened opportunities. Rather than relying entirely on LinkedIn's existing job-discovery pipeline, LinkedIn could use a partnership or data integration to identify relevant internship and new-grad postings earlier and surface them to users through LinkedIn Jobs.
- **Option 3: Improve LinkedIn's internal job search and sorting controls** LinkedIn could improve its newer AI-powered job-search experience by giving candidates more control over how matching roles are displayed. Instead of relying mainly on a small set of filters such as date posted, Easy Apply, and network connections, candidates could filter and sort matching roles by job title, years of experience, and posting date. This would not solve the underlying delay in how quickly LinkedIn discovers new jobs, but it could help users identify the newest and most relevant

opportunities more efficiently once they are available on the platform.

Chosen Direction: Option 1

Community-submitted early-career job discovery

Why I Prioritized It:

Option 1 appears to offer the best balance of speed, scalability, cost, and independence from external platforms. It directly targets the discovery-delay problem by allowing verified community contributors to surface newly posted roles before they are discovered through LinkedIn's existing pipeline.

Unlike Option 2, it does not require a long-term partnership with a third-party company, and unlike Option 3, it addresses the underlying freshness problem rather than only improving how existing postings are filtered.

However, this option introduces trust, moderation, duplicate-posting, and contributor-incentive risks that would need to be carefully tested through a limited initial rollout.

Hypothesis

If LinkedIn introduces verified community-submitted early-career job links, **then** students and recent graduates should discover and engage with relevant internship and new-grad postings earlier in the recruiting process, **because** they would be supported by a community of contributors who are actively searching for the same types of opportunities.

Experiment Design

Control:

Users experience the current LinkedIn Jobs flow, where internship and new-grad opportunities are surfaced through LinkedIn's existing job-discovery pipeline.

Treatment:

Users receive the same LinkedIn Jobs experience, but with an added stream of newly opened internship and new-grad roles submitted by verified university students or recent graduates. LinkedIn would validate contributors through university or work email addresses and verify submitted job links against official employer domains before surfacing them.

Target Population: University students and recent graduates in the United States who are actively searching for internships and new-grad opportunities on LinkedIn.

Success Metrics

Primary Metric: Measure the median time between a newly opened internship or new-grad role becoming available on an employer's official careers page and that opportunity being surfaced to eligible users through LinkedIn Jobs.

Secondary Metrics: Applications started within the first 24 or 48 hours of a posting becoming available; percentage of community-submitted roles that receive candidate engagement.

Guardrails:

- **Posting freshness:** Track how long community-submitted roles remain active and remove or flag roles that have already closed or been filled.
- **Posting quality:** Monitor the percentage of community-submitted jobs that are fake, spam, duplicated, or not linked to an official employer source.
- **Application quality:** Monitor whether faster job discovery causes a meaningful increase in low-relevance or low-quality applications.

Risks and Tradeoffs

- **Risk 1: Fake or malicious postings.** Community submissions could expose students to fraudulent job listings that attempt to collect personal information or redirect applicants to illegitimate companies

or websites.

- **Risk 2: Stale community-submitted roles.** Students could spend time applying to roles that have already closed or been filled if community-submitted postings are not removed or updated quickly enough.
- **Main Tradeoff:** Community submissions could improve the speed and coverage of early-career job discovery, but increasing the number of contributors also introduces greater privacy, security, and content-quality risks. LinkedIn would need enough verification and moderation to protect users without slowing the submission process so much that the freshness advantage disappears.

What I Would Not Build Yet

I would not build an AI agent that automatically searches for and adds job postings in an attempt to solve LinkedIn's job-discovery delay.

Why:

Although an AI agent could appear to be a fast solution, it would still depend on a reliable job-discovery and verification process underneath it. If LinkedIn has not first established a trustworthy way to identify, validate, and remove job postings, automating that process with AI could amplify duplicate, stale, inaccurate, or fraudulent listings.

I would first validate whether the community-submission model can improve job freshness while maintaining trust and posting quality before adding an AI automation layer.

Decision Framework

- **Launch if:** Community-submitted roles are surfaced materially faster than LinkedIn's existing discovery pipeline, while maintaining acceptable posting quality and low rates of fake, duplicate, or stale listings.
- **Iterate if:** The feature improves job-discovery speed but creates scaling, moderation, or quality issues as contributor and posting volume grows. In that case, I would refine contributor verification, moderation workflows, and rollout limits before broader expansion.
- **Stop if:** Community submissions do not meaningfully improve the time between a role appearing on an employer's careers page and being surfaced on LinkedIn, or if trust and safety problems outweigh the freshness benefit.